

# THE CATCH

SAME RULES. LOUDER CONSEQUENCES.

## OFFICIAL RULEBOOK — HOW TO PLAY

### PLAYERS

**2 – 6 per phone**

### ROUNDS

**7 matches**

### TIME

**20 – 40 min**

### YOU NEED

**The deck + 1 phone**

### ALSO

**Online mode**

The Catch is a dating card game with a phone for a matchmaker. The phone shows you who's on the market. The cards hold their secrets. Peek, bluff, date or ghost — then flip the cards, add them up, and find out who you really went home with.

♥ **DATE**

☹ **GHOST**

🔍 **STALK**

📱 **TRAIT CARDS**

## SECTION 01

# WHAT YOU NEED & HOW TO START

## IN THE BOX

|                       |                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>64 trait cards</b> | Green, yellow and red flags with their point values.                                                               |
| <b>6 blank cards</b>  | 3 green (+2) and 3 red (-2) to write your own.                                                                     |
| <b>30 stalk chips</b> | 3 per player.                                                                                                      |
| <b>How-to sheet</b>   | The one-page version of this book, plus 2 rules cards.                                                             |
| <b>One phone</b>      | The companion: <a href="https://bymayawalsh.design">bymayawalsh.design</a> → The Catch → ► PLAY. No app, no login. |

## 1 Who's Playing

Add 2–6 players on the phone — a name and a player type each. The cards are the game; the phone just shows who's on the market and keeps score.

## 2 Pick a Player Type

Your type changes what every card is worth to *you*. Apply it yourself when you add up your cards.

💖 **The Romantic** — every green flag +1

🎯 **The Selective** — every negative -1 more

🔥 **The Chaotic One** — negatives +2 (max 0)

🌀 **The Overthinker** — -1 → -3, 0 → -1

📖 **The Avoidant** — +3s -1, -2s & worse -1

💰 **The Gold Digger** — +2s & up +1, -2s & worse -1

## 3 Write Your Own (Optional)

Write real behaviors you've seen on the blank cards and shuffle them into the deck. They play like any other card — green blanks are +2, red blanks are -2.

## 4 Set the Table

Shuffle the deck and put it face-down in the middle. Give everyone 3 stalk chips. Press START — the phone lines up 7 profiles, and one of them is secretly a **Catfish**.

## SECTION 02

# HOW A MATCH WORKS

1

## Meet the Profile

The phone shows who's on the market: name, age, archetype, a bio and an illustrated avatar.

2

## Deal

Deal 6 cards off the top of the deck: 2 face-up, 4 face-down. Those six cards are this person.

3

## Stalk

Spend a chip to secretly peek at one face-down card, then put it back. Everyone sees you stalk; nobody sees what you found.

4

## Decide

On 3, everyone says DATE or GHOST out loud at the same time.

5

## Flip, Add Up & Enter

Flip the face-down cards. If you dated, add up all 6 cards using your type and type your total into the phone. If you ghosted, tap GHOSTED. The phone scores the match and shows the leaderboard. Discard the six cards.

### ♥ DATE

TABLE

Add up all 6 cards for your type. A negative total costs a heart. Always allowed.

### ○ GHOST

3 EACH

Pass for  $\pm 0$  — or +1 if it was the Catfish. When your 3 ghosts are gone, you have to date.

### 🔍 STALK

3 CHIPS

Secretly peek at one face-down card. Stack chips on one profile if you like.

### 📱 THE PHONE

COMPANION

Shows the profile, applies the bonuses and penalties, keeps the leaderboard and hands out titles.

## SECTION 03

## SCORING &amp; TRAIT CARDS

| CARD                            | VALUE    | COLOR      |
|---------------------------------|----------|------------|
| Green Flag — good vibes         | +1 to +3 | ● Mint     |
| Yellow Flag — mildly concerning | 0 to -1  | ● Gold     |
| Red Flag — actual problems      | -2 to -3 | ● Neon Red |

Write-your-own cards score +2 (green) or -2 (red).

## 6

## Your Type Changes the Math

The printed value is the base. Run every card through your type before you add up — a Romantic's +2 is a +3; an Overthinker's -1 is a -3. That total is what you enter.

## 7

## Hearts

Everyone starts with 3. You lose one each time you DATE and your total is negative — and dating the Catfish always costs one. At 0 hearts you're **Heartbroken**: every positive score is halved.

## THE PHONE ADDS THESE FOR YOU

**Total -5 or worse**     Red Flag — lose 2 more points

**Total 7+**     Chemistry — +2, but only if you were the only one who dated them

**Heartbroken**     Positive scores halved

## 🔗 THE CATFISH

One profile in matches 2–5 is secretly a Catfish. Nothing on the phone gives it away — it's revealed only after everyone has entered their scores. DATED it: -4 on top, plus a heart. GHOSTED it: +1.

## SECTION 04

# ENDGAME & TITLES

8

## After Match 7

The highest total wins. Tied? Whoever kept more hearts wins. Still tied? You share it.

9

## Everyone Gets a Title

The phone gives every player a title based only on their final score — the winner and everyone else.

### FINAL TITLES

#### 18 or more

The Catch — every call landed. Everyone at the table wants your number.

#### 10 – 17

The Romantic — your heart led the way, and it mostly paid off.

#### 1 – 9

The Situationship — some sparks, some red flags. It's complicated.

#### 0 or less

The Red Flag Magnet — it wasn't you. (It was a little bit you.)

### 👑 PLAY AGAIN

Shuffle everything back together — discards and all — and press PLAY AGAIN. Seven new profiles, a new Catfish, and a chance to change your title.

## SECTION 05

# QUICK REFERENCE

**EACH PLAYER GETS**

|                    |                       |
|--------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>Hearts</b>      | 3                     |
| <b>Ghosts</b>      | 3                     |
| <b>Stalk chips</b> | 3                     |
| <b>Player type</b> | 1, for the whole game |

**EACH GAME HAS**

|                   |                                         |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>Matches</b>    | 7, each dealt 6 cards                   |
| <b>Catfish</b>    | 1, somewhere in matches 2–5             |
| <b>Used cards</b> | Discard; reshuffle if the deck runs out |
| <b>Titles</b>     | Everyone gets one at the end            |

**WHO DOES WHAT**

|                  |                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The table</b> | Deal, stalk, decide out loud, flip, add up your own cards with your type                                                                      |
| <b>The phone</b> | Shows the profile, takes everyone's totals, adds Red Flag / Chemistry / Heartbroken, reveals the Catfish, keeps the leaderboard, gives titles |

**ADDING UP, FAST**

Add the printed values first, then fix only the cards your type changes. Romantic with two green flags? That's +2 on top. Say your total out loud before you type it — the table keeps you honest.

## SECTION 06

# PLAYING ONLINE

Not in the same room? Online mode deals the trait cards digitally, on everyone's own phone. Same rules — the phones just do the dealing and the math.

1

## Join a Room

Press ↗ PLAY ONLINE. One player taps **CREATE A ROOM** and shares the 4-letter code; everyone else taps **JOIN A ROOM**. Each player picks a name and a type. You need at least 2 players.

2

## Your Hand

Every phone is dealt the profile's 6 trait cards — 2 face-up, 4 face-down — drawn just like the printed deck. Tap a face-down card to **stalk it**: it spends a token and flips for you only.

3

## Decide & Reveal

Everyone taps **DATE** or **GHOST** in secret. When the last player locks in, every card flips, the host's phone scores everyone for their type, and the leaderboard updates. The host moves to the next match.

### HOW ONLINE DIFFERS

|                        |                                                            |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Cards</b>           | Dealt on screen — no deck needed                           |
| <b>Stalk</b>           | Tap a face-down card · 3 tokens each                       |
| <b>Adding up</b>       | Done for you, with your type                               |
| <b>Everything else</b> | Same: hearts, ghosts, Red Flag, Chemistry, Catfish, titles |

## SECTION 07

# STRATEGY & TIPS

**Watch who stalks**

A peek is secret, but the chip isn't. Someone stalked and then ghosted? They probably found a red flag.

**Bluff your peeks**

Found a +3? Hesitate. Found a -3? Look pleased. Your face is a card too.

**Catfish detection**

Anyone could be the Catfish, and the phone won't tell you until it's too late. In matches 2–5, a profile that looks too good is worth a stalk before you date it.

**Save ghosts for the worst**

You only get 3, and when they're gone you have to date. Don't spend them on profiles that might be fine.

**Chase chemistry**

A great date only earns the +2 if you're the only one who went. Sometimes the best move is the one nobody else makes.

**Protect your hearts**

At 0 hearts your good dates only count half. Down to 1? Ghost the risky ones.

**Know your type's math**

A yellow-flag-heavy profile is fine for a Chaotic One and a disaster for an Overthinker. Before you say DATE, count the cards your type changes.

**THE GOLDEN RULE**

Every profile has 6 cards. You see 2 before deciding. Everything else is a bet. The game isn't about being right — it's about making better bets than everyone else.